If We're Using a Surrogate, How Come I'm the One with Morning Sickness?

By Marco Pennette

Holiday Muzak plays in the darkness. A department store. Lights up on a Man holding shopping bags filled with present. Santa Claus is in the distance. He suddenly turns to the audiences, frustrated.

MAN: Un-believable. First words out of his (Santa's) mouth – "Have you been a good girl for mommy?" *(Shakes his head)* Why am I surprised? They all say it – Waitresses, salespeople. "Where's your mommy?" "Is Daddy giving Mommy a break?" Why should Santa be any different? But instead of pretending I didn't hear it, I turn to him and yell, "Hey, fat boy, she doesn't have a mother!" *(Back to audience)* Okay, actually I say nothing. I've got this thing with confrontation. I once had to see a therapist to help me break up with my other therapist. Besides, is it really my job to educate them all? I never asked to be the poster boy for gay parenting. I just wanted a child.

INTRODUCTION

Researchers estimate that the number of children nationwide living with at least one gay parent ranges from six to 14 million. And believe it or not. . . The American Academy of Pediatrics states that children are just as well adjusted in families with gay parents.

That's what the research shows . . . However, public and religious opinion is slow to change . . . On Jan. 6, 2012 Republican presidential hopeful Rick Santorum told a New Hampshire audience that children are better off with a father in prison than being raised in a home with lesbian parents and no father at all. And on Monday, January 9, 2012, Pope Benedict called gay marriage a threat "to the future of humanity itself," citing the need for children to have heterosexual homes.

But I repeat, the research on families headed by gay couples doesn't back up these dire assertions. In fact, in some ways, gay parents may bring talents to the table that straight parents

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don't . . . their children may have the advantage of open-mindedness, tolerance and respect for anyone with differences. After all, family is about taking care of your children and respecting one another. Does it really matter what your sexual orientation is?

If We're Using a Surrogate, How Come I'm the One with Morning Sickness? by Marco Pennette follows one male couple from the decision to have a child, through the surrogacy process, to the amazing day of their daughter's birth; and explains why "Where's your mommy?" "Is Daddy giving Mommy a break?" is still a struggle to hear from our society.

MAN: Growing up, it was never a question I'd get married and have a family. It wasn't till I was twelve, and my father couldn't get us tickets to Annie and I started hyperventilating on the kitchen floor, that it became clear that I probably wouldn't be marrying a woman. When my partner, Steve, and I decided to take the leap into parenthood, we'd been together eight years. That's like fifty-six in hetero-time.

Our gay friends reacted in their typical low-key demeanor. *(Mock terrified)* "A baby?! What are you thinking? You own a suede sofa from Armani Casa!" The straight folks were also supportive in . . . their way. One of them actually said, "Isn't it hard enough to raise a child in a normal family?" We crossed her off the godmother list.

The first thing we had to do was find an egg donor and a surrogate. It's preferred if these are two different people. The agency we were working with soon matched us with a potential surrogate – Donna. A perky lesbian from Simi Valley. Healthy, a mother of two. Her profile said she wanted to help gay people become a family so she can show her kids the brave new world they live in. So, we have this very bizarre "first date" at Starbucks with Donna and her girlfriend and basically try

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to cover everything in two hours – "Where'd you go to school? "Would you abort in the event of Down syndrome?" "Oh, we love *Zena: Warrior Princess*, too!" Six lattes later we're all jittery and love each other and agree to move forward.

Next, it's time to begin our egg hunt. Every night Steve and I look at photos and read profiles. I fight for looks, he fights for brains – I remind him we live in Los Angeles. When our child isn't asked to her senior prom, he can sit in her room with her and do calculus. And just when we're convinced there isn't a candidate with the genetic makeup good enough for us, we find her. Donor 6247. A month later, sixteen eggs are extracted from this angel, and as per the agreement we never see or hear from her again.

Steve and I are then called to the fertility center to do our part. We are escorted to separate "deposit closets" . . . or "masturbatoriums" . . . you get the idea . . . and this nurse hands me a specimen cup the size of a Big Gulp and tells me Go! I start sweating. Two minutes later, Steve knocks on the door to tell me he's finished, and I tell him I'm freaking out and I need a little support. He tells me to hurry up 'cause our meter's almost out. What a good father he'll be. But the threat of a parking ticket does the trick, and I quickly finish up. Seventy-two hours later, we pick one lucky egg to transplant into Donna's womb. And then we hold our breath . . . for ten very long days.

I'm at work when Steve calls. He's crying. Now, Steve cries when he

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watches a *Little House on the Prairie* re-run, so I'm not sure if we're pregnant of if Pa burnt down the barn. But then he gets it out – he says we did it – we're having a "gayby." We swear to each other we won't tell anyone for three months. We tell everyone that afternoon.

We talk to Donna at least two times a day. She is the most amazingly responsible person I know, yet every night, visions of her doing bumps of crystal meth at some rave party dance in my head. When we visit her I sneak into her kitchen and go through her garbage to make sure there aren't any empty cans of mercury-tainted tuna fish. It's a long nine months. But we're in the home stretch. And my latest fear is what happens the moment this baby is born. I want to make sure the doctor knows to hand the baby to Steve and me, not to our surrogate. I become obsessed – we need to bond with the baby instantly. The baby comes to us.

So, the big day arrives. Donna, her girlfriend, Steve and I sit in this hospital room. The nurses tell us everything looks good, nothing to do but wait. Four hours later, the contractions are a minute apart, and Donna's allowed to start pushing. At this point I whisper again to the obstetrician – the baby comes to us. Now, Donna originally had wanted us to stay up at her head while the baby was being born – which was fine with me. Saw one of those things in the Nineties, never need to see it again. But when the baby starts crowning, she yells, "Get down there! You can't miss this!" And as always, she's right. Steve actually helps catch our daughter as she's being delivered. Then the nurse wraps her

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in a blanket and I hold my daughter for the first time. I look up and see Donna watching us – sweaty, snotty, tears running down her cheeks – and once again, all plans out the window. I instantly hand the baby over for her to hold – as it should be. She wanted to make us a family. And she did.

Sometimes we don't feel so different from everyone else . . . and other times it's "Where's your mommy?" And as I look at my now-three-year-old daughter, I realize it's my turn to show my child the brave new world she lives in. So as she gets off Santa's lap, I turn to him and say *(To imaginary Santa)* "Hey, buddy, there is no mother. She doesn't have one. She just has two people who love her more than anyone ever could. And that's her Daddy and her Papa." My daughter pipes in, "That what makes me special." And I think it couldn't get any better . . . but then I hear the little girl behind us burst into tears. And when her mother asks her what's wrong, she says, "I only have a daddy. I want a papa, too!" *(Smiles)* Brave new world.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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